

A metaphysician's systemic-functional turn

Amie Thomasson's *Rethinking Metaphysics* and the autonomy of syntax

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Abstract

Thomasson's (2025) *Rethinking Metaphysics* brings a grammatical debate into metaphysics. Thomasson's metaphilosophy draws on systemic functional linguistics to explain why noun-term recastings and modal vocabulary don't have to track objects or worldly joints. The borrowing is architecturally risky. Thomasson is right that expressions have discourse roles and that metaphysicians often extend one tracking model across discourse. But her conclusions don't require placing discourse roles inside grammar. A distribution-first, autonomy-of-syntax account preserves the pragmatic payoff of noun-term recasting while keeping syntactic category, syntactic function, and discourse role distinct.

Keywords: systemic functional linguistics; conceptual engineering; lexical category; syntactic function; discourse role; grammatical metaphor; autonomy of syntax; metaphilosophy

I INTRODUCTION

What's surprising about Thomasson's (2025) *Rethinking Metaphysics* is that the constructive half of the book is organized around a Hallidayan way of asking what language is for. Thomasson turns to systemic functional linguistics to explain why easy ontological inferences are acceptable, why metaphysical disputes so often misfire, and how conceptual engineering should begin.

That should matter to linguists. A debate internal to grammar – whether discourse roles organize syntax or are better kept distinct from syntactic description – has become part of a live metaphilosophical project. This paper's claim is correspondingly double. Thomasson is right that linguistic roles matter for metaphysics. Her best results, though, don't require the systemic-functional placement of those roles inside grammar.

2 THOMASSON'S SYSTEMIC-FUNCTIONAL TURN

Part I of *Rethinking Metaphysics* has a diagnostic role in the book's metametaphysical argument. It asks whether familiar projects can supply a uniform standard for legitimate metaphysical discourse:

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joint-carving, grounding, truthmaking, causal access, or explanatory contribution. Thomasson's answer is no. These projects look for the wrong kind of standard. The constructive half changes the question. Instead of asking what all metaphysical discourse has to do, it asks what different linguistic resources let speakers do, how they entered the language, and whether they should be retained, revised, or rejected.

Systemic functional linguistics enters here. Thomasson says that SFL gives her a way to identify discourse roles and explain why philosophically suspicious expressions can still be in good order (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 133–160). Her central examples are familiar from easy ontology: if the barn is red, then there's a property, redness; if there are two cups on the table, then the number of cups on the table is two (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 169–179). A critic hears these transitions as cheap routes to abstract objects. Thomasson hears them as legitimate linguistic moves, useful because of what the derived formulations let speakers do.

Halliday's background claim isn't just that language is useful. In Halliday and Matthiessen's statement of the theory, language simultaneously construes experience, enacts social relations, and organizes discourse. The three modes are the ideational, interpersonal, and textual metafunctions. They're called METAFUNCTIONS because, in the theory, function is internal to linguistic architecture: "the entire architecture of language is arranged along functional lines" (Halliday & Matthiessen, 2014, pp. 30–31). That's the architectural claim at issue in this paper.

Thomasson uses the architecture most directly through what she, following Halliday, calls GRAMMATICAL METAPHOR. In Hallidayan terms, a meaning has a more congruent wording and can also be construed through another grammatical form. Thomasson stresses that the resulting claims aren't fictional or merely figurative: grammatical metaphor is a way mature language extends what speakers can literally say (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 154–156).

In the easy-ontology cases, grammatical metaphor introduces noun terms. *The barn is red* supports *The barn possesses [the property of redness]*; *There are two cups on the table* supports [*The number of cups on the table*] *is two*; *May was born on a Monday* supports [*The event of May's birth*] *occurred on a Monday* (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 169–179).

I call these local cases NOUN-TERM RECASTINGS. For Thomasson, abstract-object vocabulary misleads when philosophers carry over expectations from nouns like *barn* and *cup*. The bracketed NPs are grammatically ordinary, but their discourse role is to package qualities, cardinalities, and events for reference, comparison, and theory-building. They don't have to introduce objects on the model of observable things.

SFL helps Thomasson move from negative deflationary arguments to a positive method for metaphysics as conceptual engineering. Her method asks us to identify an expression and the congruent or base formulation against which it's analyzed, then ask what needs that base formulation served and what the incongruent formulation adds (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 203–207). That substantive use of linguistic theory in philosophy calls for linguistic assessment.

3 FUNCTION, ROLE, AND PLACEMENT

The word FUNCTION is the source of the slippage. I use three labels for three levels. A SYNTACTIC FUNCTION is a structural relation inside a construction. A Hallidayan METAFUNCTION is a theory-internal organizing dimension of grammar. A DISCOURSE ROLE is what an expression lets speakers do in a practice. These labels mark different explanatory questions, not one quantity.

For the rest of the paper, I avoid bare FUNCTION except when naming the ambiguity or reporting Hallidayan terminology. The paper's criticism isn't that discourse roles are unreal. It's that the third item shouldn't be collapsed into either of the first two.

In the first sense, familiar from *The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* (CGEL) and its descendants, a syntactic function is a relational position in constructional structure: subject, predicator, determiner, head, complement (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002). Syntactic function differs from lexical category. A determinative is a lexical category; determiner is a syntactic function.

Examples make the separation concrete: the same lexical category can occur in different syntactic functions, and different lexical categories can occur in the same syntactic function. For example, *stone* is a noun functioning as head in *a stone* but as modifier in *stone wall*; in *red wall*, an adjective fills that same modifier function.

In the second sense, FUNCTIONAL is Hallidayan. Language is described in terms of what it enables speakers to do, but that claim is built into grammatical architecture. Halliday's metafunctions – ideational, interpersonal, and textual – organize the grammar itself, rather than entering as later pragmatic uses of an independently described syntax. Thomasson adopts this picture when she turns to Halliday and Eggins for a systematic account of what she calls linguistic functions (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 139–159).

On that analysis, *The barn is red* is simultaneously an ideational relational clause, with *the barn* as carrier and *red* as attribute; an interpersonal mood structure, with *the barn* as Subject and *is* as Finite; and a textual structure, with *the barn* as Theme and *is red* as Rheme.

In the third sense, a discourse role is a pragmatic or teleological role in a practice. Thomasson has this sense in view when she asks what a stretch of discourse does for speakers, why it persists, and whether it should be retained, revised, or abandoned. Syntactically interrogative clauses show the same separation: *Did Kim leave?* asks a question; *Can you pass the salt?* makes a request; *Would you like tea?* makes an offer; and *Why not take the train?* makes a suggestion.

Thomasson's metaphysical examples make the third sense more explicit. In *The barn has the property of redness*, the relevant NP is *the property of redness*. Its discourse role isn't naming a perceptual object. The NP packages a quality so speakers can qualify it, compare it, refer back to it, and build theory with it.

For conceptual engineering, the third sense matters most. A reverse-engineering project asks what an expression is good for before deciding whether it's philosophically suspect (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 203–207). That role can be descriptive or normative: what the expression has done, what it now does, or what we'd endorse keeping it for.

Discourse roles matter. The question is where a grammatical theory should locate them. A distribution-first grammar can agree that noun-term recastings let speakers quantify, qualify, package information, and build theories. It can also agree that modal language serves social and normative ends. These roles may belong in the broader property cluster or projectibility profile associated with a construction. The open question is whether those roles are category-making conditions for syntactic category or syntactic function. The roles are real; the placement is optional.

Thomasson's borrowing becomes linguistically interesting at this point. For philosophers, systemic functional linguistics offers an attractive corrective to representational monism: many expressions earn their keep without naming or tracking an object. For an autonomist syntactician, the corrective comes bundled with an architectural choice. Halliday is right to insist that expressions serve

multiple discourse roles. On this view, his mistake is building those roles into the syntax.

That last claim is about explanatory placement, not about whether SFL is useful. A grammar can help identify the expressions whose discourse roles matter, and it can describe the constructions that make those roles available. The rejected step isn't including those roles in the broader projectibility profile. It's treating them as what makes an expression a noun, a determinative, a subject, or a determiner. The *CGEL*-style objection doesn't say Halliday is wrong to notice that clauses, phrases, and NPs can do similar discourse work. It says shared discourse work shouldn't be recoded as syntactic category.

4 GRAMMATICAL METAPHOR AND THE CATEGORY/DISCOURSE-ROLE CONFOUND

Grammatical metaphor is the pressure point. Thomasson is careful to block a bad philosophical reading of the term. In her Hallidayan use, GRAMMATICAL METAPHOR names a relation between congruent and incongruent grammatical realizations.

Among the easy-ontology examples, the cases that matter here are noun-term recastings: *red* in adjectival use can support [*the property of redness*]; the cups case shifts from a cardinality claim to a number-ascription, *There are two cups on the table* to [*The number of cups on the table*] *is two*; an event description can support [*the event of May's birth*] (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 154, 169–179). The resulting claims aren't make-believe. Mature language lets speakers recast material across grammatical forms.

These noun-term shifts really do add capacities (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 155–156). They let speakers count, qualify, increase lexical density, package earlier claims, and construct layered theories. This lets Thomasson say that systemic functional linguistics gives her a new answer to a question left open by easy ontology: why would a language contain apparently redundant transitions from *the barn is red* to *the barn has the property of redness*? Such transitions are useful. They let speakers do work that the base formulations don't do as well.

But usefulness isn't validity. Thomasson had already defended the easy inferences by appeal to introduction rules, redundancy, and ordinary linguistic competence before the systemic-functional apparatus enters the 2025 book (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 34–39). She also says that, when she wrote *Norms and Necessity*, she hadn't yet discovered systemic functional linguistics (Thomasson, 2025, p. xiv); the modal-normativist program was already in place (Thomasson, 2020). The SFL material helps explain why the NP formulations are worth having. By itself, it supplies no rule that licenses the inference.

This distinction matters because the SFL vocabulary can make a category contrast look like a discourse-role explanation. In the property case, the contrast is between adjectival and NP formulation. In *CGEL* terms, that's a contrast in category and construction. The pragmatic payoff is a further fact about what the NP construction lets speakers do. If we collapse the two, we risk treating an expression's usefulness as if it explained its syntactic status, or treating a syntactic category assignment as if it by itself justified an ontological inference.

Thomasson's own later discussion pushes in the same direction. In Chapter 9, she says that the formal-functional analysis is incomplete on its own. Knowing that modal expressions or noun-term recastings serve broad formal roles doesn't yet distinguish the discourse roles of different modal flavors or different grammatical metaphors. For that, she adds a needs-based, material analysis: identify the base formulation, then ask what needs or desires it serves and what the corresponding grammatical

metaphor adds (Thomasson, 2025, pp. 204–207). That’s a retreat from pure grammatical architecture to a broader pragmatic genealogy.

Keep the discourse-role turn. Thomasson’s strongest conclusions survive a less Hallidayan grammar. She needs the claim that expressions have many roles, that noun-term recastings expand what speakers can do, and that treating all nouns on the model of observational object tracking produces pseudo-problems. The stronger claim that those roles belong inside syntactic description is dispensable. Halliday gives her a powerful diagnostic vocabulary, but the inferential work is done by easy ontology plus framework-neutral facts about what the resulting NPs let speakers do.

5 WHAT LINGUISTS SHOULD MAKE OF IT

First, linguistic theories travel. When they travel into philosophy, education, law, or cognitive science, their internal disputes often disappear from view. Thomasson’s reader may come away thinking that Hallidayan grammar is simply what linguistics says once it takes discourse roles seriously. That would be a mistake. It’s one powerful tradition within linguistics, not the neutral name for role-sensitive grammatical explanation.

Second, autonomist grammarians shouldn’t answer Thomasson by denying the discourse-role facts. Noun-term recastings let speakers package qualities, cardinalities, and events as NPs, so that the resulting material can be counted, modified, specified, and developed theoretically. Modal vocabulary does do normative and social work. The better answer is to separate those facts from the claim that the grammar itself has to be organized by the roles. The autonomy of syntax isn’t the claim that language has no uses. It’s the claim that syntactic description shouldn’t be made hostage to a prior inventory of discourse roles.

Third, Thomasson’s examples expose a bad projection: an NP needn’t support the same ontological inferences merely because it’s an NP. Syntactic categories support syntactic projections. The metaphysical question concerns a different target: which uses of NPs, especially NPs introduced by noun-term recastings, license which existential, explanatory, or practical inferences, under which conditions. That projectibility question belongs mainly to the companion philosophical argument. Here, it’s enough to keep the levels apart.

For linguists, then, *Rethinking Metaphysics* is both an opportunity and a warning. The opportunity is to show philosophers that detailed grammatical distinctions matter for live metaphysical questions. The warning is that, if linguists don’t keep lexical category, syntactic function, and discourse role explicit, philosophers will inherit whichever architecture arrives bundled with the vocabulary they need. Thomasson needed a way to say that abstract-object talk can be useful without being observational object tracking. SFL gave her that way. A clearer grammar can keep the insight and remove the unnecessary commitment.

6 CONCLUSION

Thomasson’s systemic-functional turn is a real event in the afterlife of linguistic theory. A major metaphysician has used SFL to rebuild the constructive part of metaphysics around the roles of discourse. Linguists shouldn’t treat that as someone else’s local philosophical borrowing.

Better, then, to avoid both dismissal and conversion. Thomasson is right that metaphysicians have often mistaken one discourse role for the role of language as such. She’s also right that grammatical recastings introducing noun terms explain why some abstract-object talk is ordinary, useful,

and philosophically innocent. The caution is narrower: those results don't require the Hallidayan decision to put discourse roles inside syntax. They require a plural account of what linguistic expressions do, plus a grammar that keeps lexical category, syntactic function, and discourse role in view without collapsing them.

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